

INTERFACE AND PERFORMANCE

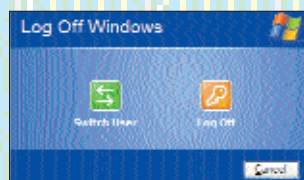
Start off your XP experience with tips on enhancing its looks and performance

Speed up the Start menu

The Start menu takes quite a while to display the list of programs installed. In order to get Windows XP to display the list faster, you will have to edit the registry settings. But before you set about doing this, remember to back up your registry before making any changes. To speed up your Start menu, go to **Start > Run** and type **regedit**. This will open the registry window. Then navigate to the following key: **HKEY_CURRENT_USER \Control Panel\Desktop** folder. Thereafter, scroll down in the right panel and double-click on the menu 'Show Delay File'. In the Value Data box, change the default value for the menu speed from 400 to a lesser number, such as 1 or even 0. Click OK. You should now find a significant increase in the Start menu speed.

Switching users

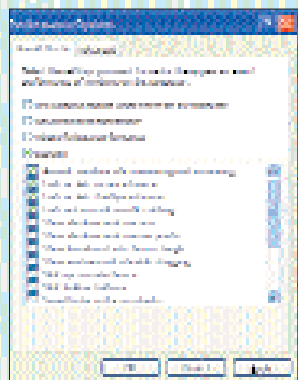
XP allows you to switch users without actually quitting programs and logging off. To make use of this, go to **Start > Log off**. You will be greeted with an option of



'switching user' wherein another user can log on without you having to quit your program(s).

Modifying visual settings

If you have only 128 MB RAM, your machine might be a bit sluggish after installing Windows XP. So to achieve optimal performance without buying additional RAM, disable certain visual settings and free up some precious memory. Go to the Control Panel, click



Boost performance by reducing visual settings

on the Advanced tab in System, and choose Settings under the Performance option. Change various graphical effects. Uncheck the animation and shadow options as they tend to consume a lot of memory. You should get a better response from your OS now

without spending any money on RAM.

Enabling/disabling Clear Type

Microsoft has introduced a new technology called 'Clear Type' with Windows XP. However, it is not enabled by default. To enable it, right-click on a blank area of the Desktop and choose Properties. Click on the Appearance Tab and click again on Effects. Check the box 'Use following method to smooth edges of screen fonts' and in the drop-down box select 'Clear Type'.

Clearing Document list

The Start menu of Windows XP has been completely revamped and made extremely customisable. If you want the Start menu to display

only the applications that you want, right-click in an empty section of the Start menu's left column and select **Properties > Start menu > Customise**. Then go to the General tab, click on Clear List, and set the counter to zero. Now no one can keep track of the programs or

applications you've recently used.

The 'Classic Look'

If you are not comfortable with the new look of Windows XP, you can easily switch back to the old classic look of Windows. Right-click the desktop, select



Properties, click the Themes tab and choose Windows Classic from the drop-down list. The old Windows 2000 look is ready.

Grouping/ungrouping taskbar items

Try opening more than three windows of any program, for instance Internet Explorer, and you will see them automatically grouped together under a single button. This happens